

Series Title: Entering the Passion of Jesus

Dates: March 9 - April 20

Vision For The Event

This is our first chance in a long time to have the entire church studying the same material in all areas of ministry. The sermons, small group and Sunday school curriculum, as well as the youth and children's lessons will all follow *Entering the Passion of Jesus* by Amy-Jill Levine. This curriculum is an introduction to the Gospel stories of Jesus' passion. Our challenge will be to make the stories and the lessons from the book fresh and new for our seasoned saints through our sermons and teaching.

The success of the series should be evaluated by how well it:

- Unites the church in a common study.
- Breathes new life into the annual stories of the passion.
- It acts as a launching pad for discipleship discussions.

Chat GPT Summary:

Summary of *Entering the Passion of Jesus* by Amy-Jill Levine

In *Entering the Passion of Jesus: A Beginner's Guide to Holy Week*, renowned biblical scholar Amy-Jill Levine offers a fresh and engaging exploration of the events leading up to Jesus' crucifixion. Levine examines the stories of Holy Week through a combination of historical, theological, and literary lenses, helping readers better understand their significance and relevance.

Key Themes and Insights:

1. The Context of Risk

Levine emphasizes that Jesus' actions during Holy Week were inherently risky. By entering Jerusalem, overturning tables in the Temple, and challenging religious and political authorities, Jesus knowingly put himself in danger. The book invites readers to consider their own willingness to take risks for their beliefs.

2. Reinterpreting the Stories

Levine explores well-known events such as the Triumphal Entry, the Cleansing of the Temple, and the Last Supper, providing historical and cultural context. For example, she

sheds light on how Jewish traditions inform these events, encouraging readers to see them from new perspectives.

3. The Role of the Disciples

The book examines the actions of Jesus' disciples, including their loyalty and their failures. Levine reflects on what these stories teach about human vulnerability, responsibility, and faith.

4. Justice and Compassion

Levine highlights Jesus' focus on justice and compassion, particularly through his interactions with marginalized individuals. She challenges readers to reflect on how they live out these values in their own lives.

5. Theological Reflection

While deeply rooted in historical scholarship, Levine also invites readers to explore the theological significance of Jesus' passion. She discusses themes of sacrifice, redemption, and the nature of God's kingdom.

6. Invitation to Participate

Levine frames Holy Week not just as a series of past events but as an ongoing invitation for believers to engage with its spiritual and ethical challenges.

Sermon Schedule

Sunday	Sermon Title	Scripture	Supplemental Scriptures
3/5	Ash Wednesday	Matthew 6:1 –6, 16–21	Joel 2:1-2, 12-17
3/9	Risking Reputation	Matthew 21:1-11	Luke 19:39-40
3/16	Risking Righteous Anger	John 2:13-21	Isaiah 56:6-7
3/23	Risking Challenge	Matthew 22:15-22	1 Peter 2:12-13
3/30	Risking Rejection	John 12:1-8	1 Samuel 2:7-8 & Mark 14:9
4/6	Risking Lost Friends	Luke 22:14-27	1 Corinthians 11:23-26
4/13	Risking Temptation	Mark 14:32-52	Isaiah 53:12
4/20	Easter		

Week 1 | Risking Reputation - Matthew 21:1-11

This is the fever pitch of Jesus’ earthly ministry. Jesus is never more popular than the week before his death. He is a rock star and a beloved politician all rolled into one. Yet his entry into the holy city is portrayed in direct contrast to that of the Roman rulers. He rides in not on a white horse but a donkey. The cries of Hosanna from the people are better understood as requests of salvation. “The whole Triumphal Entry scene is one of anticipation, but it cannot be read alone. The parade into Jerusalem, with all the hype and hope, leads directly to the cross (page 36).”

Week 2 | Risking Righteous Anger - John 2:13-21

Righteous anger is more tricky than it ought to be. We often justify our own anger by referencing the time Jesus got angry at the temple. However, righteousness is not subjective. Also, unlike much of our own anger, Jesus’ righteousness was not directed at a person but at systems of injustice. How can we use Jesus’ example of anger to better understand the things that should and should not cause us to express anger as well? “Righteous anger seeks restitution; it seeks correction, not retribution (51).”

Week 3 | Risking Challenge - Matthew 22:15-22

In the week leading up to Jesus' crucifixion he takes time to teach — a lot. The amount of Jesus' teaching depends on which Gospel you are reading. Taken as a whole, we find his teaching on many subjects, including; money, greatness, giving, government, and more. Not being residents of Israel in the first century we always run the risk of misunderstanding aspects of Jesus teaching. In fact, even those closest to Jesus often misunderstood his teaching. However, in almost all of the things Jesus chose to teach about there exists a challenge to existing norms. Jesus teaching weren't meant to comfort but to conflict.

Week 4 | Risking Rejection - John 12:1-8

"Jesus states, 'Truly [that is, "amen"] I tell you, wherever the good news is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will be told in temperance of her.' (Mark 14:9). Do we tell the story in her memory (93)?" This chapter gives us the chance to learn about, remember, and celebrate the women in Jesus' ministry. The women Jesus encounters throughout his ministry risk much. Whether it is touching his robe or pouring out costly perfume, their witness teaches us what it means to risk everything in order to be close or bring honor to Christ.

Week 5 | Risking Lost Friends - Luke 22:14-27

The story of the last supper is the penultimate story in the passion narrative. This is the night before the night. In this story we have deep symbolism of, "Jesus *as* the Passover offering (115)." The Son of God is betrayed, and yet still breaks bread with his betrayer. Jesus redefines the Passover meal. And, Jesus teaches us what true servanthood looks like. When we choose to live like Christ we risk altering our lifestyle in such a way that our decisions appear foreign to even those closest to us. Yet, to truly follow Christ is to risk sacrificing those relationships we hold most dear.

Week 6 | Risking Temptation - Mark 14:32-52

What is the garden of Gethsemane, a place of agony or triumph? It depends on which Gospel account we read. Regardless, in all accounts it is Jesus' way out. It is the chance for Jesus to remove himself from the impending crucifixion. Yet, even with the temptation to prevent the misery that is on the horizon he chooses to willingly continue on the journey to the cross. There has never been a greater risk of temptation, nor a greater example of someone overcoming being tempted.